

How to take two connections from a single DTH?

There are three different ways for using a single DTH connection for multiple TVs:

1. In some set-top boxes there is a line-out facility which helps to have another connection to TV, but you will receive the same channels in both the TVs because the STB is the controller for both the TVs.
2. Buy second STB and have a splitter hardware (this is a device connected at the low-noise block converter (LNB) to share the signal for both the STBs) to connect the two STBs. There is no need of additional dish.
3. Have two STBs and two LNBs with the same dish.

time, don't buy that DTH connection. To test how fast you can zap through channels, press 'channel up' key very fast about ten times, and if the tenth channel tunes (gets visible on the screen) after more than five seconds, it's not worth buying.

Reminders should work as expected. Check how easy is it to set reminders and favourites, browse channels and see the programme schedule. The EPG should be user-friendly and devoid of mistakes in data. Also check the language options. Also, is it possible to create your own lists of channels that you watch most often? If yes, how many channels can be added to your favourite list? Check for the number of days of programming schedule being offered. This will help you in planning your TV viewing in advance.

How convenient is it to recharge your account? Check for the payment options available—Internet, mobile phone, voucher and auto-debit. Go for the broadcaster which has the biggest network of vendors and service centres. This is useful especially if you are not comfortable with the options of recharging online or through the mobile. Just walk-in at the nearest shop and pay for the bills.

Interactive applications are important if you are looking for more than channel surfing. You can get your favourite recipe when you want at the press of a button. Watch a cricket match with exclusive features like choice of commentary language, highlights on-demand and player statistics. Interact with TV programmes or other things in real time. If you love to see movies, you can watch

the latest blockbusters on pay-per-view basis.

Advertisements or promotional campaigns generally do not mention hidden costs. So do inquire the dealer about hidden costs like maintenance and installation charges.

Among the things that deserve not much consideration are MPEG version, multiple channels per screen and the number of features. MPEG-4 is an advanced version of MPEG-2 compression technology which allows for availability of more bandwidth. So more channels can be sent from the same transponder. Of course, MPEG-4 is better for the broadcaster but as an end user, it doesn't affect you much.

Multiple channels per screen should be your last consideration. These are nothing but mosaic descriptors. Seeing 8-12 programmes per screen is only going to confuse you. In fact, it just helps you to find quickly about the programmes on various channels in visual format.

Last but not the least, don't go by the number of features being published by broadcasters. These are used by DTH service providers to trick the consumers. All the broadcasters in the Indian market are offering almost the same features (EPG, reminders, favourite lists, multiple channels per screen, parental control, etc). It's just that they are marketing these under different names.

In a nutshell, go by the performance of the set-top box and not the marketing gimmicks. ●

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